

The Story of An Afghan Diplomat's Daughter

Warm regards, Excellency ladies and gentlemen

My name is Kawsar Bashiry and I am 17 years old. I am from Afghanistan, and I have one brother and one sister Omar and Rehab who are younger than me.

My father was a diplomat, and my mother was a stay-at-home mom. I'm going to share my life's journey, the difficulties I and my family experienced before coming to Canada and also why we think Canada is a better place to live in than any other country.

Canada 2006:

During his 15 year mission as a diplomat, my father travelled to more than 45 countries. In September 2006, my father travelled to Canada as a protocol officer to prepare the President of the Islamic Republic of Afghanistan, His Excellency Hamid Karzai's meetings and official visit plans in Canada.

During their 13 day stay in Canada, he searched and studied closely the lives of and the level of knowledge and education of the people in Canada especially my father's presence at the Canadian headquarters gave him the opportunity to meet the former Prime Minister Stephen Harper and other members to learn more about Canada.

My father decided to move to Canada when he quit his job because he believed it was a much better place to live than any other country, also In Turkey, he told us that human rights and the rights of immigrants are fully respected and there is freedom of speech and the conveniences of life are provided for all citizens of the country and also the Canadian government provides financial assistance to people who are interested in studying, including loans for college and university education, etc.

From that time I also became interested in being able to do my studies in Canada. The most **interesting** and **historical** thing for me is that I was born on September 25, 2006, the day my father was in Canada.

Saudi Arabia: 2010-2012

Due to my father's official duty, we travelled to Jeddah when I was three years old as my father graduated from Al-Azhar University and obtained his master's degree from Cairo University. He was fluent in Arabic and could speak it easily, but my mother could not speak Arabic.

Although my father was a diplomat, the three-year period in Saudi Arabia was not pleasant for him, there were restrictions on women's rights, human rights, and freedom of expression.

If you disrespect the King or any member of their family in Saudi Arabia, you will face jail time, many people are beheaded and executed every year, foreign workers who work are looked down upon, and Foreigners cannot buy land and houses in their name.

Anyway, my mother, my siblings, and I were not really happy in Saudi Arabia. Since we had no family members and could not communicate in Arabic, we had no choice but to stay at home most of the time. We would visit parks when my dad was home because no woman has the right to drive a car.

Afghanistan, Kabul: 2013 to October 2015

After three years of staying in Saudi Arabia, we had to return to Afghanistan due to the termination of my father's job.

We were happy to return home because our whole family was present. But there were also terrible things, the Taliban were fighting with the government, they were targeting the schools, there was even an explosion on the road in front of our school, we were all scared, and the financial conditions of the people were still very bad and the people were not at peace.

We were happy since we could visit our family frequently and because my brother and I had an easy time in school because everyone spoke our language and I had lots of friends like here in Canada.

Turkey: November 2016 to November 2018

Two years of living in Turkey were very good and useful for me. I started the third grade at (Murat Beyaz) School. I was meant to be in grade 6, but I had to go to grade 3 since I couldn't speak Turkish. When I first began class, I was nervous since I didn't know how to speak Turkish, I didn't have any friends, and I was also older than all of the students. At first, I had no idea what my

teacher or my classmates were saying and was completely confused. But my class turned out very welcoming and I got to meet a lot of kids. It took me five or six months to become fluent in Turkish and fully understand what my friends were saying.

My mom got to know the wives of several of my dad's friends. Since they were each from Afghanistan, My dad used to come home late and leave early in the morning, so I barely got to see him, he participated in the ceremonies and invitations of foreign consulates residing in Istanbul I also remember that on a regular basis, he would get calls in the middle of the night telling him to go pick up someone important and VIP people at the airport.

To be completely honest, I really enjoyed our time in Turkey and felt happy there

During long vacations, my father took us to tourist cities in Turkey, we saw the cities of Trabzon, Antalya, Marmaris, Cappadocia, Ankara, and other beautiful cities, we lived in the best hotels, and I always remember the delicious Turkish food.

In 2018, my father decided to quit his job because he was threatened by the Taliban and he wanted me and my siblings to have a good education and be safe, so my dad decided we should come to Canada because when he was in Canada in 2006 he knew so many things about here and knew it's a great place to live.

In November 2018, I remember beginning seventh grade. I was anxious on my first day because I didn't know anyone but the principal, the teachers, and my classmates were really kind.

My little understanding of English helped me to understand what they were saying. I quickly made friends who were assisting me in catching up on my studies. My family and I have felt very welcome for the past 5 years. Canada is a really good country for a few reasons.

First, people from all over the world live here, and everyone is treated fairly. They believe in having different cultures together.

Second, Canada takes care of its people. The healthcare is good, and there are programs to help if you need support. The country is also beautiful with big mountains, forests, and lakes. Canadians care about the environment and try

to keep it clean. The government works well, and everyone gets a say in how things are done. Canada is liked by many because it's a friendly and nice place to live in. Canada is known for being a safe and peaceful country. People here follow the rules, and there's not a lot of trouble. Education is also important, and there are good schools and universities in Canada. In terms of work, Canada provides opportunities for many. The job market is diverse, and the government supports worker's rights. They want people to have good jobs and earn a fair wage. In conclusion, Canada's strengths lie in its safety, education, friendly communities, and job opportunities, making it a great country to live in. I want to see everyone happy and together.

Thank you so much for reading my story!

Best Regards,

Kawsar Bashiry

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